

**₹1,262 CRORE**
'MISSING' FUNDS IN KCR KITS SCHEME FOR EXPECTANT MOTHERS

**"TELANGANA'S DEBT BURDEN HAS GONE UP 10 TIMES SINCE 2014...BECAUSE OF THE INDISCRIMINATE BORROWINGS OF THE FORMER KCR REGIME"**
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ability will cross Rs 3 lakh crore by the end of 2024-25.

A not inconsiderable part of Telangana's debt is the Rs 1.2 lakh crore in off-budget borrowings (OBBs), and a big chunk (Rs 66,854 crore) of that is for the Kaleshwaram Irrigation Project Corporation Ltd (KIPCL). The maximum repayment spread period of OBBs was 14 years and future liability on the Kaleshwaram project towards debt servicing worked out to around Rs 1.4 lakh crore over the next 10 years (see box *The White Elephant*). 'This will constitute a huge burden on state finances, constraining them severely and the capacity of the state to have any developmental plans in the near future,' the CAG report says.

On the power utilities, the report pointed out that they had not divulged details of how some Rs 16,000 crore had been utilised. Documentation regarding risk assessment for guarantees given was also not provided. 'Even the guarantees which should have been classified as direct 100 per cent liability, were being classified as medium to very low risk,' the CAG observed.

The CAG report reveals the tardy performance and lack of accountability even in welfare schemes like sheep distribution and rearing and the 'KCR kits' for poor expectant mothers. The records for year-wise payments of Rs 1,261.7 crore were unavailable for audit purposes, though the government claimed nearly 1.4 million expectant mothers had benefited from the 'KCR kit' direct benefit scheme, which was implemented to improve the numbers in institutional deliveries, Infant Mortality Rate (IMR) and Maternal Mortality Ratio (MMR). The government was to pay Rs 12,000 for boys and Rs 13,000 for girls born to the very poor in deliveries at government healthcare facilities.

In the sheep-rearing scheme, there were serious lapses in maintaining data of the beneficiaries and keeping invoices to support the transport of the animals. The scheme was introduced in 2017 to provide sustainable livelihoods to the traditional shepherd families. At the time itself, livestock industry experts had cautioned that most of the sheep would be on the "biryani lover's plate" before long. The audit has discovered invoices with fake vehicle registration numbers, those showing transport of more sheep than was possible or permitted, even 'recycling' of sheep (the same animals were shown as given to different beneficiaries). The anti-corruption and vigilance inquiries, initiated after the Congress assumed office, have detected suspected fraud of Rs 254 crore so far.

The CAG report also shines the light on another stark reality. The audit found that budgetary grants were made but huge amounts remained unspent in the Dalit Bandhu empowerment scheme, the scheme for building 2 BHK houses for the rural and urban poor and special development fund for welfare activities.

On the positive side, the BRS can justifiably claim to have drawn investments to develop Greater Hyderabad and spur the growth of the urban econ-